

## Getting and Installing Python

The most obvious place to get Python is the official Python website at <http://www.python.org>

As we have mentioned before, there are two versions of Python currently supported and available on the Python website. We will need to download and install the latest version of Python

3. As of this writing that is Python 3.4.3, although 3.5 is just a few months away.



There are also a number of non-official alternative Python editions

available. Some of them are just versions that a commercially supported, however others bring their own unique features. For instance Jython is Python running on the JVM and as such can interface easily with Java code; IronPython runs *on .NET* and can *use .NET* features. Another interesting case is PyPy, which can be much faster than regular Python in many use cases. Enthought's Canopy is a good choice for beginners and comes with a simple IDE, and Anaconda Python is optimised for working with large datasets in scientific computing.

We'll just use the plain old official Python version here and you should too (although you can ActiveState's ActivePython since it is entirely compatible). When installing the official version of Python 3 on Windows make sure to select the option to add python.exe to the PATH environment variable since this makes Python programs much easier to run. Once it is installed, you can run Python scripts using the 'python' command. If you don't add python.exe to the PATH environment variable you will need to run Python scripts by providing the complete path as 'C:\Python34\python.exe' or wherever you have installed Python 3.

For Windows users what we have described above works well, however Linux, and OSX both come with Python pre-installed, and chances are it might not be Python 3. If you are using some Linux distribution, you may need to check if Python 3 is installed, and install it if it isn't. Here are the commands to install Python 3 on some of the popular distros:

Debian-based (already installed on Ubuntu): `apt-get install python3`

OpenSUSE-based: `zypper install python3`

RedHat-based (Fedora): `yum install python3`

Arch-based: already installed

For our readers running OSX on their Apple computers, you will find that Python 2 comes preinstalled with the OS. You can download an install